

World in Brief: Iran warns ships in Hormuz; Ukraine and Russia trade strikes



Photograph: Getty Images

Iran said two ships trying to pass through the Strait of Hormuz using an “unsafe route” were involved in an unspecified “accident”. In a warning broadcast on state-affiliated television, the Islamic authorities said they had deterred two others. [America](#) launched heavy attacks against Iran on Saturday for the eighth night in a row, after two American servicemen were killed in Jordan a day earlier. Sixteen Americans have died in the war.

Ukraine hit four fuel-infrastructure facilities in southern Russia and oil tankers in the Black Sea. The attacks follow a major Russian strike on Kyiv, the Ukrainian capital, before dawn on Sunday; Ukraine’s foreign minister said it was the largest since the war began. One person was killed and 16 were injured. The city has too few Patriot missiles to defend itself against such strikes.

South Korea will let foreigners open won accounts in foreign institutions in a bold push to make its [currency](#) easier to trade globally. From 2027 investors will no longer need to route won transactions through Korea. Asia’s fourth-largest economy has long tightly controlled its foreign-exchange markets.

At least eleven people died and several were missing in flooding in the Indian-administered state of **Jammu & Kashmir**. Flash floods

submerged roads and triggered landslides. Large rescue and relief efforts are under way as more torrential rain is expected in the coming days. Global warming seems to be causing more intense bursts of rain during the monsoon, bringing [new dangers](#).

Allies are watching nervously as the strategically located archipelago of **São Tomé and Príncipe** votes for its next president. The incumbent, Carlos Vila Nova, is seeking re-election after falling out with the ruling party. The former Portuguese colony, which sits off the coast of Africa, is an important base for fighting maritime piracy in one of the world's hotspots. But the [island-state's](#) recent military agreement with Russia has worried European allies.

Jens Spahn resigned as parliamentary leader of Germany's ruling [Christian Democratic Union](#) after coming under scrutiny for fathering a child through surrogacy in America. German law prohibits the practice, and Mr Spahn had previously opposed efforts to legalise it. Church leaders and the Frauen Union, the CDU's women's wing, called on him to step down. Friedrich Merz, Germany's chancellor, called his resignation "unavoidable".

England beat **France** 6-4 to take third place in the [World Cup](#). **Kylian Mbappé** broke the all-time scoring record for the tournament with his 22nd goal. On Sunday [Argentina and Spain](#) will face off for the trophy. In what will probably be his last World Cup, Argentina's captain [Lionel Messi](#) could still snatch back the "Golden Boot" title for top scorer from the French striker.

Word of the week: Albedo, the amount of sunshine the Earth reflects into space. [Read our cover story](#) on how global dimming is making the world hotter.

Hong Kong learns from Beijing



Photograph: Getty Images

On Sunday members of Hong Kong's parliament arrived in Beijing for their first collective visit to China's capital since Britain handed the territory back in 1997. But the trip will be far from a week-long jolly. The goal is for Hong Kong's legislators to "better grasp the central authorities' governance philosophy and development strategies". Lest they misunderstand their role as students, the parliament's administrative council has reportedly issued uniform-like ties and scarves.

Geopolitics, national security and, crucially, China's five-year plans, will all feature on the syllabus. China has long practised this ritual of central planning—it is on its 15th cycle. Hong Kong will soon draft its inaugural plan, which will "proactively align" with the mainland's framework. Janice Tse, Hong Kong's secretary for mainland affairs, insists that this alignment "does not replace the [free market](#)". Yet the lawmakers would hardly be expected to return from their school trip full of [capitalist zeal](#).

Messi chases history at the World Cup final



Photograph: Getty Images

Ahead of this year's [World Cup](#), FIFA introduced a tennis-style seeded draw for the tournament. This ensured Spain and Argentina, the world's two highest-ranked teams, were kept apart until the final. It worked. After 103 matches, the two sides will meet in New Jersey on Sunday.

Spain are the favourite. The European champions have been miserly in defence (conceding just one goal all tournament), imperious in midfield and clinical in attack. But if Spain's path to the final has been a triumph of the collective, Argentina's has been one of the individual—[Lionel Messi](#).

Though the South American squad has often struggled in matches, the 39-year-old has dazzled, scoring eight times and providing four assists. When Mr Messi led Argentina to World Cup victory in 2022, many declared him the greatest-ever to play the game. Should Argentina become the first side to retain the trophy since Brazil in 1962, that crown would be [undisputed](#).

North Africa's drying desert threatens Europe's health



Photograph: Getty Images

As climate change has made the Sahara desert drier, wind has blown more of its dust to Europe. This is worrying because mineral desert dust—composed of elements like aluminium, titanium and iron—is a big contributor to atmospheric particulate matter, PM_{10} , which can penetrate deep [inside the lungs](#). A study published this week in *Nature* took the first continent-wide reading of dust levels over the past decade and their effect on mortality.

Researchers compiled over 18,000 daily dust measurements from 103 sites across Europe. Analysing PM_{10} concentrations between 2012 and 2021, they found that dust in southern Europe and the Mediterranean had risen sharply, particularly over Italy and the Adriatic and Aegean seas. By 2021, wind-blown desert dust accounted for 31% of the “guideline” annual limit for PM_{10} . Southern Europeans experienced on average 46 “dust episodes”—spikes above average—each year, which caused a 0.67% rise in the rate of daily deaths.

Dust pollution will only increase as climate change accelerates, the authors conclude. The threat to public health, too, will only worsen.

Weekend profile: Sir Christopher Nolan, Britain's most important director since Hitchcock



Photograph: Reuters

Sir Christopher Nolan can seem stuck in the past. The seventh-highest-grossing film-maker of all time refuses to use email or buy a smartphone. Tom Shone, a film critic, has described him as “a very familiar type of Englishman...the kind of upper-middle-class son of the home counties one could imagine with a career in the City who plays rugby with his fellow brokers on the weekend”.

But the director likes to play tricks with time. “Memento” (2000), his breakout feature, tells one story chronologically and another in reverse. “Dunkirk” (2017) weaves three storylines together. In “Tenet” (2020) objects and people move forwards and backwards through time. “The Prestige” (2006) features teleportation. “The Odyssey”, which opens this weekend, plunges viewers into an ancient Greece that mirrors the modern West ([not always successfully](#)).

A desire to escape the present can be traced back to Sir Christopher's childhood. Born in London in 1970 to a British father and American mother, he attended Haileybury, an English boarding school he later described as “Darwinian”. He escaped its miseries

by disappearing into worlds inside his head. “I certainly prized the imaginative space of listening to music in the dark,” he recalled.

Sir Christopher’s 12 feature films are defined less by his conservatism than by a slippery inventiveness. “Inception” is about corporate espionage in people’s dreams. “Interstellar” (2014) features wormholes, black holes and tesseractes. Even “Oppenheimer” (2023), a biopic of an American theoretical physicist that won him Academy Awards, jumps between the 1930s, 1940s and 1950s.

But on set Sir Christopher is a stickler for regularity. He films from 7am to 7pm, with only a brief break. He usually finishes on time and within budget. He likes to work with family: his wife, Emma Thomas, produces his films; he often writes with his brother, Jonathan; all four of his children worked on “The Odyssey”. And he has a regular stable of actors. “You wouldn’t know he’s the director,” said Sir Michael Caine, one frequent collaborator. He is “very quiet, very confident, very calm”.

His method has gained him fans. “The Odyssey”, the first film shot entirely with large-format IMAX cameras (a format that produces sumptuous images but is harder to work with than digital cinematography), is already a box-office success. Britain’s biggest IMAX screen sold 28,000 tickets in 24 hours, more than double its previous sales record. Opening-weekend screenings at 16 American IMAX theatres sold out as soon as tickets went on sale a year ago. As with his other films, Sir Christopher’s dedication to the technical work of film-making has already made “The Odyssey” a hit, even if it treats the subject matter with less reverence.

Mini crossword

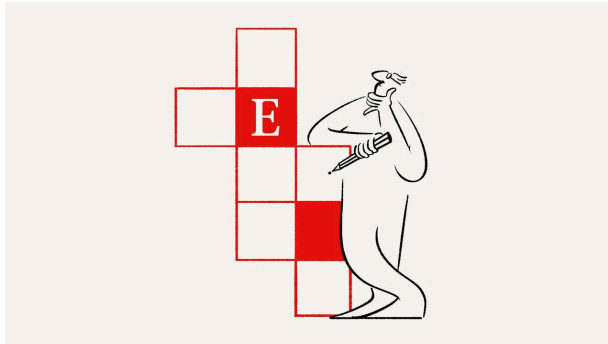


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Beginning drink after Rio dancing (6)

2 across - Delight a poet (5)

3 across - Tired, slippery one turns up - caught by secret agent (6)

1 down - Billionaires unravel hair clogs (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Source; inception (6)

2 across - Tickle, make laugh (5)

3 across - One of seven from 1937 film (6)

1 down - Abramovich & co (9)

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Kharim Schliewinsky, Halifax, Canada

Jos Aarts, Nijmegen, the Netherlands

Fred Chambers, London, Britain

They all gave the correct answers of: Uncle Remus, Gemini, the Bee Gees, Jimmy Olsen and Minnesota.

The theme was twins: Remus (along with Romulus) was one of the mythological twins who founded Rome, the Gemini Zodiac sign is for twins, Maurice and Robin Gibb (along with Barry) were twin founders of the Bee Gees, the Olsen twins are well-known actresses, and Minnesota's baseball team is the Twins.

The questions were:

Monday: Joel Chandler Harris wrote books featuring which African-American story-teller?

Tuesday: What is the name of Google's AI assistant?

Wednesday: Which pop group won five Grammy awards for the “Saturday Night Fever” soundtrack?

Thursday: What is the name of Clark Kent’s young sidekick at the Daily Planet in the Superman stories?

Friday: Which American state is known as the “Land of 10,000 Lakes”?

*Art is not what you see, but what
you make others see.*

Edgar Degas